THE RISE OF THE ITALIAN MARITIME REPUBLICS

THE ITALIAN CITY-STATES of Venice, Genoa, and Pisa grew rich on seaborne trade and providing transport and naval support for the Crusades. Their rivalry for control of trade routes from the Levant and the Black Sea led inevitably to conflict. Pisa was knocked out of the competition by defeat at the hands of Genoa in 1284, while Venice and Genoa fought one another to exhaustion in four inconclusive wars between 1253 and 1381. The battles between Venetian and Genoese galley fleets often resulted in crushing losses for one side or the other, but defeat had little long-term effect as new galleys were built and fresh crews were recruited. Losses of merchant convoys to commerce raiders often had more strategic significance. By the 15th century Genoa was becoming exhausted while Venice faced the task of defending its scattered possessions in the eastern Mediterranean against the rising power of the Ottoman Empire.



THE ITALIAN MARITIME REPUBLICS c.1050–1400

Although their territorial possessions were negligible, the Italian maritime republics gained extraordinary wealth through trade with the east—especially in silks and spices. Venice acquired a string of ports on the Adriatic and the coasts of Greece, while Genoa had trading posts in Greece and even on the Black Sea.

KEY

- Venetian Republic and possessions c.1270
- Republic of Genoa
- Republic of Pisa
- Genoese victory
- Venetian victory
- Inconclusive battle

NORMAN–BYZANTINE WAR

DURAZZO



Date June 1081
Forces Venetians: 59 ships; Normans: 150 ships
Losses unknown

Location Adriatic, off modern-day Albania

When Norman adventurer Robert Guiscard conquered Sicily and southern Italy, threatening Venetian shipping in the Adriatic, Venice agreed an alliance with the Byzantines. In spring 1081 Guiscard sailed with 30,000 men from Brindisi, captured Corfu, and besieged the city of Durazzo. A Venetian fleet under Doge Silvio arrived to confront the Normans anchored in the city's harbor. During the night the doge had his largest ships anchor in a line, with cables looped from ship to ship, making an impassable barrier described as a "sea harbor." Behind this he positioned his war galleys.

In the morning the Normans, led by Guiscard's son Bohemond, attacked. The Venetians had built towers on their ships, which were manned by soldiers armed with heavy timbers studded with iron spikes. When the Norman ships were halted by the Venetian barrier, the soldiers hurled the timbers down to smash holes in their hulls. Bohemond's ship was one of those sunk. Retreating from this bombardment, the Normans were pursued to shore by the Venetian galleys and routed. The battle marked a significant step in the rise of Venetian maritime power.

FIRST VENETIAN–GENOESE WAR

TRAPANI



Date June 1266
Forces Genoese: 27 ships; Venetians: 24 ships
Losses Genoese: entire fleet; Venetians: none

Location Off western Sicily

During the first war between Genoa and Venice, Venetian admiral Jacopo Dandolo's galleys sailing round Sicily met Lanfranco Borbonino's Genoese fleet sailing south from Corsica. Aware that most of his crews were Lombards with no seafaring skills and no battle experience, Borbonino adopted a static defensive formation, cabling his galleys together with their sterns to the shore. The Venetians, experienced sailors inspired by patriotic fervor, launched a vigorous and noisy attack, exciting terror in the Lombards who abandoned ship in droves, making for the nearby shore. Three of the Genoese galleys were burned and the rest captured.

PISAN–GENOESE WAR

MELORIA



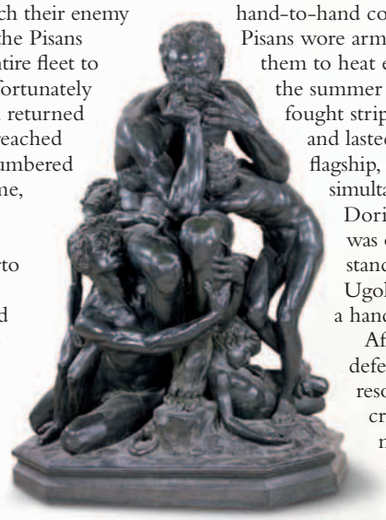
Date 6 August 1284
Forces Genoese: 93 galleys; Pisans: 72 galleys
Losses Genoese: unknown; Pisans: c.40 galleys, c.10,000 casualties and prisoners

Location Off Livorno, Italy

Genoa and Pisa went to war in 1282 over control of the islands of Corsica and Sardinia. In the summer of 1284 the Genoese sent part of their fleet to Sardinia under the command of Benedetto Zaccaria. Seeing an opportunity to catch their enemy at a disadvantage, the Pisans dispatched their entire fleet to attack Genoa. Unfortunately for them, Zaccaria returned just as their ships reached the city. The outnumbered Pisans fled for home, with the Genoese, under the overall command of Oberto Doria, in pursuit. The Pisans reached the safety of Porto Pisano, at the mouth of the Arno, but were lured out by a ruse. Doria drew up his own 63 galleys in a line offshore; Zaccaria's 30 galleys lurked behind with their masts lowered. Believing they had the numerical advantage, the Pisans' Venetian commander Alberto Morosini and his second-in-command Ugolino della Gherardesca led their 72 galleys out to sea. By the time they saw Zaccaria's galleys coming up to join Doria, it was too late to retreat.

The Pisans fought fiercely against the odds. The opening exchange of missiles—bolts fired from crossbows, stones hurled by mangonels—was followed by boarding and murderous hand-to-hand combat. Many of the Pisans wore armor, which exposed them to heat exhaustion under the summer sun; the Genoese fought stripped to their shirts and lasted better. Morosini's flagship, eventually under simultaneous attack from Doria and Zaccaria, was overcome and the standard cut down. Ugolino escaped with a handful of galleys.

After this catastrophic defeat, Pisa lacked the resources to build and crew a new fleet. It never regained its status as a naval or commercial power.



Survivor of Meloria
Ugolino later starved to death in captivity with his sons and grandsons, an event narrated in Dante's *Inferno*.